

Animal Implicatures: A Note on the Informativity Principle and Bayesianism*

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September 9, 2026

Abstract

Several recent analyses of animal signals have proposed that when animals have the choice between a signal S and a more informative signal S^+ , S^+ is preferred if it is true (= Informativity Principle). The principle is usually taken to apply both in production and in comprehension. A Gricean analysis currently lacks plausibility for lack of evidence for a theory of mind in the target species. But this doesn't mean that the animal Informativity Principle must be entirely taken as primitive. In fact, some uses of the principle in comprehension can be replaced with simple Bayesian reasoning. We explain in which cases this happens, and why the key data adduced for the Informativity Principle cannot be explained in this way because they involve production rather than comprehension. This suggests a new division of labor in which the animal Informativity Principle is primitive in production, but derived from Bayesian reasoning in comprehension.

Keywords: animal linguistics, animal communication, animal semantics, animal signals, Bayesian pragmatics, Informativity Principle

Statement on the use of AI. For the present version, AI (notably, Claude) was solely used to provide feedback and critical remarks. We experimented with more radical uses of AI, for instance to perform simulations and write a separate text. We ended up not making use of these results.

1 The Informativity Principle in animal linguistics

Several recent analyses of animal signals developed within “animal linguistics” (e.g. Schlenker et al. 2014, 2016a,b,c) have postulated an Informativity Principle:

(1) **Informativity Principle** (from Schlenker et al. 2016c)

Assume that the semantics yields a relation ‘is strictly more informative than’ on some signals that are alternatives to each other. Underinformative signals are prohibited by the following rules:

- a. *Production:* Do not utter S in a situation w if a strictly more informative alternative S^+ is true in w .
- b. *Comprehension:* If you perceive S in a situation w , infer that every strictly more informative alternative S^+ is false in w .

* *Grant acknowledgments:*

Schlenker: this work was supported by a Research Award of the Humboldt Foundation (Germany).

Spector: this work was supported by a grant from the Agence Nationale de la Recherche (ComCogMean project, ANR-23-CE28-0016).

All: we acknowledge support from the Agence Nationale de la Recherche (FrontCog project – ANR-17-EURE-0017)

Acknowledgments: We thank Mélissa Berthet for discussion of the Titi data.

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In its human incarnation, the Informativity Principle derives “implicatures”: an expression S that competes with a more informative expression S^+ is pragmatically enriched to S and not S^+ (e.g. Grice 1989; Horn 1972; Gazdar 1979; Hirschberg 1991; Sauerland 2004; Schulz and van Rooij 2006; Spector 2007; Frank and Goodman 2012; Goodman and Stuhlmüller 2013; Franke and Jäger 2016; Degen 2023, among many others).

A key motivation for the animal version of the Informativity Principle comes from the stylized observation in (2a), which is primarily based on monkey vocal behavior.

(2) **Stylized motivation for the Informativity Principle**

Several species have a call S used for diverse dangerous situations (e.g. situations where there is a predation and non-predation-related situations), and a call S^+ used only for specific predators, typically eagles. Then:

- a. *Production* [actual argument]: When there is an eagle stimulus, signalers standardly produce sequences of S^+ signals, not of S signals.
- b. *Comprehension* [possible argument]: When there is an S signal, receivers behave as if there were a non-eagle-related threat.

In recent animal linguistics, the Informativity Principle is taken as primitive in production and in comprehension alike. This sharply contrasts with the situation in human linguistics. In the Gricean tradition (starting with Grice 1989), the Informativity Principle is derived from the speech act participants’ ability to reason about other minds. The speaker reasons about the listener’s goals, and seeks for this reason to be maximally informative, hence the Informativity Principle in production. The listener takes into account the speaker’s cooperative behavior and thus infers that the messages are maximally informative, hence the Informativity Principle in comprehension. This derivation would make sense for our target data if there were evidence for a theory of mind in monkeys, whose calling behavior is the main argument for the animal Informativity Principle. But as things stand, such evidence is missing.

There has been active research on the existence of a theory of mind in *apes*—and in particular on their ability to represent false beliefs. Krupenye and Call (2019) argue that some experiments have yielded a positive outcome, but they also note that conclusions are different in *monkeys*: there is a “possibility that the mechanisms underlying apes’ sensitivity to others’ beliefs may have evolved uniquely in the ape lineage”.

But does this mean that the animal Informativity Principle should be entirely taken as primitive? An alternative is that part or all of the animal Informativity Principle is derived from Bayesian behavior, even without a theory of mind. As we will see, this derivation is plausible for the Informativity Principle in comprehension. But there are rich empirical arguments for the Informativity Principle in production, and this part of the principle must in the end be treated as primitive. We will thus argue for a new division of labor between the animal Informativity Principle and Bayesianism.

2 A simple Bayesian alternative in comprehension

Let us now explain why the Informativity Principle in comprehension may be derived from simple Bayesian reasoning. We consider again a Titi monkey that hears a B-call, and we assume that there is no Informativity Principle whatsoever, be it in production or in comprehension. For concreteness, let us further assume that a signaling Titi has the following behavior:

- If there is an eagle, use A with probability .5 and B with probability .5
- If there is a non-eagle-related threat, use B with probability 1.

Now suppose that relative to all threats, eagle-related threats occur with probability .5, while non-eagle-related threats occur with probability .5. These assumptions are summarized in Table 1.

It is clear that a Titi receiver that hears a B-call will take it to be more likely that there is a non-eagle rather than eagle threat, since conditional on hearing B, the probability of encountering a non-eagle is twice that of encountering an eagle, as shown in Table 1 (the probability of ‘Eagle & B’ is 0.25, while that of ‘Non-eagle & B’ is 0.5). More precisely, by inspecting Table 1, one sees that $P(\text{Non-eagle} | B) = \frac{P(\text{Non-eagle} \& B)}{P(B)} = \frac{0.50}{0.75} = 2/3$. But this means that the effect of the Informativity Principle in perception (= (1b)) is emulated without any

Situations	Eagle ($p = .5$)	Non-eagle ($p = .5$)
Calls	A ($p = .25$) B ($p = .25$)	B ($p = .5$)

Table 1: Relative frequencies of calls A and B under the assumption that if there is an eagle, Titi will produce either A or B with equal probability, and if there is a non-eagle threat they will produce a B. This Table assumes that eagle and non-eagle threats have equal probabilities $p=.5$.

Informativity Principle.¹

It is clear that this conclusion does not necessarily follow. If non-eagle threats have probability .1 rather than probability .5, as illustrated in Table 2, while eagle-related threats give rise to half of A-behavior and half of B-behavior, as before, the reasonable reaction when hearing a B-call is to think that there is probably an eagle, not that there is a non-eagle, since we now have $P(\text{Non-eagle}|B) \simeq 0.18$ (cf. Table 2: $P(\text{Non-eagle}|B) = \frac{P(\text{Non-eagle} \& B)}{P(B)} = \frac{0.1}{0.55} \approx 0.18$)

Situations	Eagle ($p = .9$)	Non-eagle ($p = .1$)
Calls	A ($p = .45$) B ($p = .45$)	B ($p = .1$)

Table 2: Relative frequencies of calls A and B under the assumption that if there is an eagle, Titi will produce either A or B with equal probability, and if there is a non-eagle threat they will produce a B. This Table assumes that eagle and non-eagle threats have unequal probabilities $p=.9$ and $p=.1$ respectively.

Let us now consider things in a slightly more general case, as described in (3).

(3) **General case**

a. *Situations*

Among all threats, eagle threats occur with probability e , non-eagle threats with probability $(1 - e)$, with $0 \leq e < 1$:

$$P(\text{Eagle}) = e, \quad P(\text{Non-eagle}) = 1 - e$$

b. *Calling strategies*

Eagle threat situation: use A with probability $1 - b$, B with probability b , with $0 < b < 1$:

$$P(A | \text{Eagle}) = 1 - b; \quad P(B | \text{Eagle}) = b$$

Non-eagle threat situation: use B with probability 1

$$P(A | \text{Non-eagle}) = 0; \quad P(B | \text{Non-eagle}) = 1$$

Now we can use Bayes's rule to compute the conditional probability of being faced with an eagle vs. a non-eagle threat contingent on hearing A or B. We remind the reader of Bayes's rule in (4), and we apply it to the case at hand in (5).

(4) **Bayes's rule**

$$P(X | Y) = \frac{P(Y | X) P(X)}{P(Y | X) P(X) + P(Y | \neg X) P(\neg X)}$$

¹In Franke's Iterated Best Response model, this derivation corresponds to a level-1 listener who responds to a level-0 (literal) speaker (Franke, 2009, 2011).

(5) **Application.**

$$\begin{aligned}
\text{a. } P(\text{Eagle} \mid B) &= \frac{P(B \mid \text{Eagle}) P(\text{Eagle})}{P(B \mid \text{Eagle}) P(\text{Eagle}) + P(B \mid \text{Non-eagle}) P(\text{Non-eagle})} \\
&= \frac{be}{be + 1 \cdot (1 - e)} \\
&= \frac{be}{be + (1 - e)} \left(= \frac{1}{1 + \frac{1 - e}{be}} \right). \\
\text{b. } P(\text{Non-eagle} \mid B) &= 1 - \frac{be}{be + (1 - e)} \\
&= \frac{1 - e}{be + (1 - e)} \left(= \frac{1}{1 + \frac{be}{1 - e}} \right).
\end{aligned}$$

Upon hearing an A-call, the receiver can infer that there is an eagle, since A-calls are only used for Eagles. When the receiver hears a B-call, the situation is more complex, as shown by (5). However, in all cases, after hearing a B-call, the hearer increases its assessment of the relative probability of a non-Eagle threat, compared to an Eagle-threat, as shown in (6).²

$$(6) \quad P(\text{Non-eagle} \mid B) > P(\text{Non-eagle})$$

Proof: $be < e$ (since $0 \leq b < 1$), therefore $be + (1 - e) < e + (1 - e) = 1$, therefore $(1 - e)/(be + (1 - e)) > (1 - e)$. $\square$

To illustrate, in Table 2 the prior probability of a Non-eagle was very low (0.1), but the posterior probability of a Non-eagle given after hearing a B-call is, as mentioned above, approximately .18, which is still low, but nearly twice as much as the prior probability.

As a result, whatever the value of e and b , upon hearing a B-call, a Bayesian receiver should pay more attention than before to the possibility of non-eagle-related threats. This is true even in the absence of any Informativity Principle, and even if b is high, i.e. even if the B-call (i.e. the general call) tends to be favored across the board, in violation of the Informativity Principle. In particular, if eagle-related threats are no more frequent than non-eagle-related ones ($e \leq 0.5$), as we assumed in Table 1, then whatever the value of b is, $P(\text{Non-eagle} \mid B) > 0.5$.³ A B-call will thus signal that a non-eagle-related threat is likely, which emulates the effect of the Informativity Principle.

More generally, the formula in (5b) implies that the posterior probability of a non-eagle-related threat after hearing a B-call increases when e and b decrease. The reason is that the function

$$f(e, b) = \frac{1}{1 + \frac{be}{1 - e}} = P(\text{Non-eagle} \mid B)$$

is decreasing with respect to its two arguments.⁴ Intuitively, this is because when the prior probability of an eagle-related-threat (e) is low, its posterior probability will tend to be low as well, and if the probability ($= b$) of using a B-call in an eagle-related-situation is low, a B-call is even more indicative of a non-eagle-related threat.

²We are only talking here about the relative probabilities of the two types of threats *conditional on their being a threat*. When hearing a B-call, the receiver learns that there is a threat, so typically both eagle and non-eagle threats become more probable than before, and if eagle-related threats are antecedently much more likely than non-eagle-related ones, the receiver should still be more concerned about eagles than non-eagles after hearing a B-call, despite the fact that a B-call increases the probability share of non-eagle-related threats relative to that of eagle-related threats.

³If $e \leq 0.5$, $be/(1 - e) \leq 0.5 \times b/(1 - 0.5) = b$, hence $P(\text{Non-eagle} \mid B) = 1/(1 + be/(1 - e)) \geq 1/(1 + b) > 0.5$ (since $b < 1$).

⁴Proof: be is increasing in e , and so is $1/(1 - e)$, and therefore $eb/(1 - e)$ is increasing in e . ($be/(1 - e)$) is also of course increasing in b . So $[1 + be/(1 - e)]$ is increasing in both e and b , and therefore $1/[1 + be/(1 - e)]$ is decreasing in both e and b .

Now in simple cases, we can assume that the receiver will adopt a non-eagle-related behavior just in case the probability of eagle presence after hearing B is less than a certain threshold θ , as stated in (7).

(7) The receiver will adopt a non-eagle-related behavior after hearing B just in case

$$\begin{aligned} P(\text{Eagle} \mid B) &< \theta \\ \text{i.e., } \frac{be}{be + (1 - e)} &< \theta \\ \text{i.e., } (1 - \theta)be &< \theta(1 - e). \end{aligned}$$

For concreteness, we can set $\theta = .5$, that is, the receiver adopts a non-eagle-related behavior if it's more likely that the threat is non-eagle- than eagle-related. The condition in (7) simplifies to (8).

$$(8) \quad be < 1 - e \iff e(1 + b) < 1$$

We can see that if e is itself equal to or smaller than 0.5, this condition holds for all possible values of b (reason: since $(1 + b) < 2$, $0.5(1 + b) < 1$).

For simplicity, we have stated the predictions in terms of eagle-related vs. non-eagle-related threats, although analyses typically posit slightly different meanings, as will be seen in the empirical discussion below.

3 Why the simple Bayesian alternative doesn't derive key data

In their landmark study of call meaning in Vervet monkeys, Seyfarth et al. (1980) based their analyses on monkeys' reactions to playbacks of their own calls. These were thus comprehension data. If the animal Informativity Principle had been motivated by comprehension data, it could be derived from Bayesian reasoning. But the empirical situation is entirely different: all the case studies that motivated the Informativity Principle were largely based on production data, as we will now see.

Titi monkeys Let us start with Titi monkeys. The analysis developed in Schlenker et al. (2016b) posits that B calls are general calls, to be used for any noteworthy event. By contrast, A-calls are used for diverse serious non-ground alerts (notably, eagle-related alerts). The key for our argument is that the main data come from production rather than comprehension experiments.

We have copied in Fig. 1 the results of Cäsar's experiment involving a model raptor in the canopy, with each line representing the first 30 calls produced. Virtually all of them are A-calls; there are a few O-calls or unidentified calls, and no B-calls at all.

Call sequences produced by **Titi monkeys** after presentation of a model raptor in the canopy

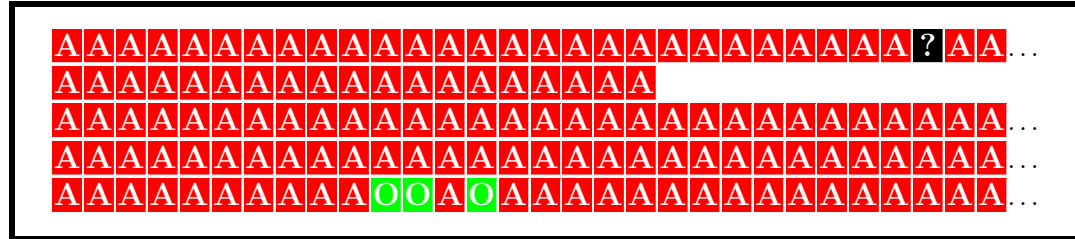


Figure 1: Titi monkeys call sequences produced in response to the presentation of a model raptor in the canopy (Cäsar, 2012). Each line represents the series of the first 30 calls: A calls (A), O calls (O), and one unclear case (?). A correction to one call transcription is due to Mélissa Berthet.

By contrast, B-calls are used for predatory and non-predatory alerts alike (including for noteworthy events that are not dangerous, such as feeding or deer presence). This was taken by Schlenker et al. (2016b) (followed

by Commier and Berthet 2019) to show that B-calls are general alert calls. On this assumption, the *absence* of B-calls in raptor in the canopy situation clearly requires the Informativity Principle.

Interestingly, production data were complemented in this case with comprehension data. Cäsar (2012) assessed in detail Titi gaze orientation after hearing A- vs. B-calls. It is clear that receivers expected a non-ground threat after hearing A-calls, as such playbacks “elicited longer looking in the upwards direction, indicating monkeys were anticipating an important event, such as a raptor attack, from above” (Cäsar 2012 p. 165). For B-calls the situation is a bit less clear: “Playback elicited longer looking towards the caller, indicating monkeys were anticipating an attack/event from near the caller”, possibly because “listeners were looking for cues from caller’s behaviour and/or body orientation” (p. 166).

Importantly, in more recent field experiments, Berthet et al. (2026) find three instances in which Titi A-calls are used for felids on the ground, casting doubt on earlier claims that they have a "serious non-ground threat" meaning. As Berthet et al. argue, this motivates a new hypothesis: A-calls are produced when the caller is in a state of high arousal, while B-calls are produced when the caller is in a state of low arousal. Because eagles are dangerous predators, their presence tends to trigger high arousal and thus A-calls, but this is not because A-calls have an "eagle" or even a "serious non-ground" component. It is clear that Berthet et al.’s (2026) hypothesis will need to be supported by more data as well as by auxiliary hypotheses linking arousal levels to environmental conditions. But what matters for present purposes is that this alternative analysis obviates the need for the Informativity Principle. Adjudicating the debate will require more Titi data. Importantly, however, several further studies have made use of the Informativity Principle, as we will now see.

Putty-nosed monkeys Putty-nosed monkeys have a general-like ‘pyow’ call and an eagle-related ‘hack’ call. Schlenker et al. (2016a) propose an articulated analysis in which pyow can be used for any alert, while hack is used for serious non-ground movement-related alerts. The "movement-related" component is motivated by an interesting twist of Putty-nosed vocal behavior: in a series of detailed field experiments, Arnold and Zuberbühler (2006a,b) showed that a small number of pyows followed by a small number of hacks triggers group movement. This observation was derived by Schlenker et al. (2016a) from the aforementioned call meanings, combined with a pragmatic principle (the "Urgency Principle") according to which calls that provide information about the location of a threat should come before those that don’t. The details of pyow-hack sequences are immaterial to the present discussion, however, and they will not be further discussed in this piece. Only the treatment of pyows as general calls is of present relevance.

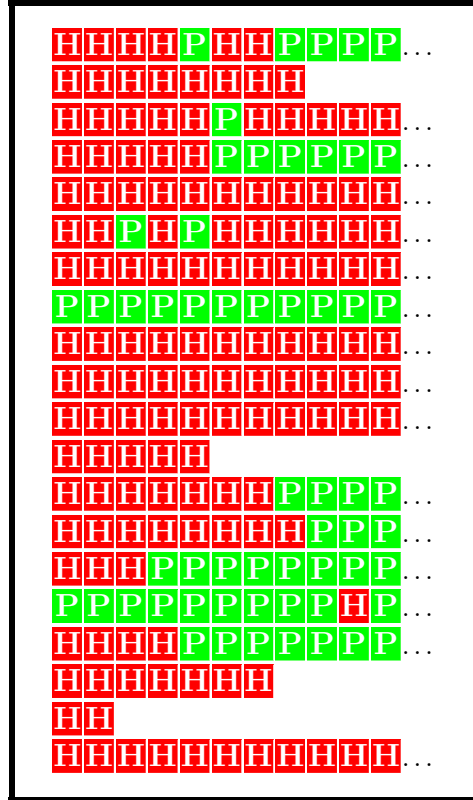
Crucially, key data regarding pyows and hacks came from production experiments, in which calling behavior was triggered by visual or acoustic models. Arnold et al. (2008) found that pyows were found throughout calling sequences triggered by leopard models. By contrast, in sequences triggered by eagle models, sequences overwhelmingly started with hack, not pyow, as seen in Fig. 2

It should be noted that in some cases, eagle calls are followed by general calls. This pattern is illustrated in Putty-nosed sequences in Fig. 2, and it is also found in Titi experiments (Cäsar 2012; Cäsar et al. 2013; Schlenker et al. 2016b). A standard line of analysis is that in some cases, the threat level typically decays after some time (Schlenker et al. 2016a,c). If Putty-nosed hack has a ‘serious non-ground’ component, alarm decay has the consequence that after a while hack can’t be used any longer (while there is a non-ground threat, it is a weak one), and thus only pyow can be used.

Blue monkeys Related conclusions were drawn by Schlenker et al. (2016c) on the basis of Blue monkey calls (unlike the other case studies discussed here, this proposal was part of a survey rather than of an article-length case study, and its conclusions are correspondingly more speculative). Blue monkeys have a common ancestor with Putty-nosed monkeys that lived 2.5 million years ago (Guschanski et al., 2013), and they have in part similar calls. In particular, they have pyow calls that occur in diverse environments, notably (but not exclusively) when there is a terrestrial predator, male-male agonism or agonism with another group (with presence in aerial predator contexts that is lower than expected by chance, but still significant). This is shown in Fig. 3 (Fuller, 2013).

Schlenker et al. (2016c) postulated that, just as in Putty-nosed monkeys, pyows are general alert calls. But there are several other calls in the Blue monkey repertoire, for instance ka calls that are used (among others) for aerial predators. In order to explain why pyows do not occur in all environments, Schlenker et al. (2016c) once again appealed to the Informativity Principle. What matters for present purposes is that,

Call sequences produced by **Putty-nosed monkeys** after presentation of an Eagle shriek



an Eagle visual model

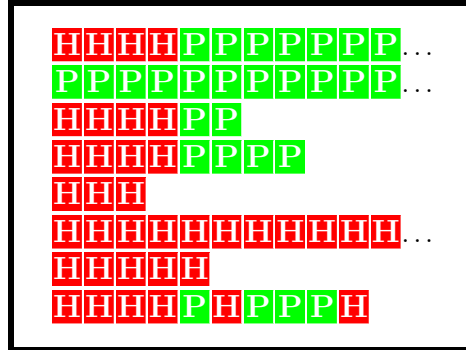


Figure 2: Putty-nosed monkeys call sequences in response to the presentation of (left) eagle shrieks and (right) visual models of an eagle (Arnold et al., 2008). Each line represents the series of the first 11 calls: hack calls (**H**) and pyow calls (**P**).

whether right or wrong, this analysis was primarily based on production data.

Campbell’s monkeys Finally, we come to a more involved analysis, that of Campbell’s monkey calling behavior. This was the very first study that made use of the animal Informativity Principle, but we discuss it last because of its complexity (Schlenker et al., 2014, 2016d). The authors start from Campbell’s monkey calling behavior in the Tai forest (Ivory Coast), where the main predators are leopards and eagles. Campbell’s monkeys use krak calls to raise leopard alerts, and they use hok calls for raptor alerts. In addition, they have suffixed calls. Krak-oo is used for all sorts of alerts, and hok-oo for non-ground disturbances (Schlenker et al., 2016d).

Interestingly, calling behavior is in part different at another site, Tiwai island (Sierra Leone), where leopards haven’t been seen for dozens of years. On Tiwai, krak is used as a completely general call.

Schlenker et al. (2016d) summarize their proposed analysis as follows:

"As a first step, we take krak to trigger unspecific alerts and hok to trigger non-ground alerts. As a second step, to analyze the meaning of the suffix -oo, we assume that if R is krak or hok, R-oo indicates a weak alert of the R type. Thus, hok-oo indicates a weak (-oo) non-ground (hok) alert, which is more informative than hok.

It is in the third step that we make crucial use of the Informativity Principle: hok competes with other calls and because hok-oo (pertaining to weak non-ground alerts rather than to any non-ground alert) is more specific, the meaning of hok is enriched to hok but not hok-oo. Thus it applies only to aerial (hok) non-weak (not hok-oo) alerts – hence the raptor uses. By the same logic, the unspecific alert krak competes with krak-oo but also with hok. Due to this competition with two more-informative calls, ultimately krak can be

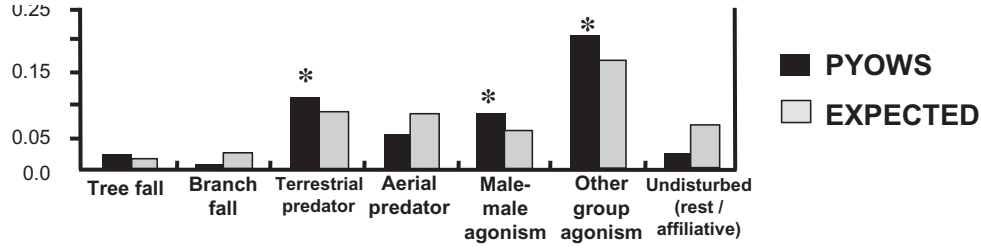


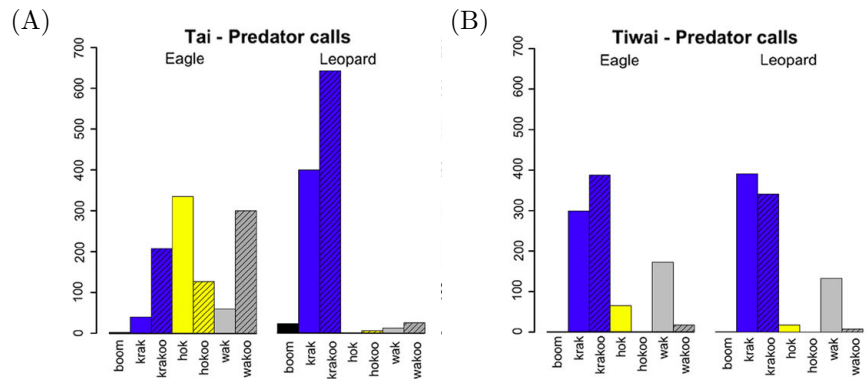
Figure 3: Use of Blue monkey Pyows. The black bars show the proportion of Pyow calls over all the recorded calls in each condition. The gray bars represent chance level in each condition, stars * indicate conditions showing a significantly higher than expected presence of Pyows. Figure cited in Schlenker et al. 2016c p. 68, adapted from Fuller (2013) p. 171.

used only for serious (not krak-oo) ground (not hok) disturbances. This comes very close to the leopard uses observed in the Tai forest."

The fourth and final step is to account for the use of krak as a general call on Tiwai island. "Strikingly, this use corresponds to the basic (unenriched) meaning of krak. The question is why this bare meaning fails to be pragmatically enriched on Tiwai. A plausible answer is that this would yield a useless meaning due to the absence of serious ground predators."

The proposal, then, is that the use of krak on Tiwai island reflects its unadorned (and general) meaning. In the Tai forest, competition between krak and the more informative krak-oo (= non-serious alert) and hok (= non-ground alert) yields a strengthened meaning of "serious and ground alert".

Once again, our goal is not to adjudicate the debate regarding the analysis of Campbell's calls (Schlenker et al. 2014 only present the competition-based analysis as a serious contender, and certainly not as the only game in town). What is crucial for present purposes is that the key data come from production experiments in which calling behavior was triggered by predator sounds or naturalistic events. For instance, the data below were obtained from field experiments involving playbacks of eagle shrieks and leopard growls in the Tai forest and on Tiwai island. The results show that krak has a general use on Tiwai island but a leopard-related use in the Tai forest, as is expected given the initial generalizations.



Number of calls of different types given in response to calls from two types of predators (left) eagles and (right) leopards by Campbell monkeys living (A) in the Tai forest and (B) on Tiwai island. Figure from Schlenker et al. (2014). p. 457

In sum, key data that motivated the Informativity Principle were based on production. The Informativity Principle in production captures these data. Simple Bayesianism does not: it is an inferential mechanism, which has nothing to say about the choice between two signals in production.

4 The division of labor between the Informativity Principle and Bayesian reasoning

We turn to the consequences of our remarks for animal semantics and its evolution.

Three Possibilities In view of the foregoing results, there are three conceivable ways of dividing the work between the Informativity Principle (viewed as primitive), pragmatics, and Bayesian reasoning.

1. Despite the skepticism mentioned in Section 1 about the existence of a theory of mind in monkeys (following Krupenye and Call (2019)), it could be that future research will make a Gricean-like derivation more plausible than it currently is.

Even without a theory of mind, however, the sender might be able to observe the receiver's *behavior*, and to reason based on this knowledge. In the future, a key question will thus be whether there is evidence for the *specific* cognitive abilities needed to derive the Informativity Principle in production from a reasoning on the receiver's behavior. This is a far more fine-grained question than has been addressed so far. The literature has uncovered audience effects—instances in which a sender takes into account the receiver's state of mind. A famous case involves chimpanzees that fail to produce snake alarm calls when their interlocutors are already aware of eagle presence (Crockford et al., 2012). In these cases, the sender might have a theory of mind, or it might observe that the receiver is better off hearing S than not hearing S , when S is true. But what we need to derive the Informativity Principle in production is something more sophisticated, namely the knowledge that the receiver is better off hearing S^+ rather than S when both are true.

A further difficulty bears mentioning. The cognitive abilities needed would have to be rather abstract. In Putty-nosed monkeys, Blue monkeys and Campbell's monkeys, alarm calls are produced by a resident male for an entire group it may not see (as the group is spread in trees). For this reason, the resident male would have to reason about the behavior of a very abstract addressee. Even without this constraint, it is hard to see how the sender could easily infer how messages affect the receiver's behavior (note that, by contrast, the sender's behavior is trivial to observe).

2. A more appealing alternative is that the Informativity Principle (taken as primitive) and Bayesian reasoning play complementary roles: the Informativity Principle is responsible for patterns of production, while in comprehension it is not primitive but follows from Bayesian reasoning.

In the case of human language, the same result can be conceptualized in two slightly different ways: (i) the addressee has access to the speaker's strategy, and thus infers from the production of a less informative expression that the more informative one was false—as in the standard Gricean approach; (ii) the addressee has access to the speaker's behavior.⁵ In the animal case, (i) might make little sense if no theory of mind is present, but (ii) makes good sense.

The proposed synthesis represents a division of labor that is not usually considered in humans (where reasoning can do everything), nor in prior work on animal linguistics. For fear of unduly committing to a theory of mind in animals, earlier animal literature took the Informativity Principle to be primitive in both its production and its comprehension sides. As we have now seen, for the comprehension side, this measure was unnecessary.⁶

3. A more conservative view is, of course, that the Informativity Principle is primitive both in its production and in its comprehension sides. On the assumption that Bayesian reasoning is prevalent in

⁵In both the neo-Gricean tradition (Grice 1989; Horn 1972; Gazdar 1979; Hirschberg 1991; Sauerland 2004; Schulz and van Rooij 2006; Spector 2007, a.o.) and in the Bayesian pragmatics literature (Frank and Goodman 2012; Goodman and Stuhlmüller 2013; Franke and Jäger 2016; Degen 2023, a.o.), the pragmatic listener draws inferences on the basis of their knowledge of the speaker's behavior in different situations. This knowledge can in principle come either from reasoning about what a rational speaker would do, or from *observing* what the speaker typically does. While the first option (reasoning about the speaker's optimal strategy) is typically assumed in human pragmatics, it is not a necessary component of the analysis.

⁶Importantly, on this view the Informativity Principle in production could be probabilistic rather than deterministic. In our stylized example above, for the Informativity Principle in comprehension to be derived, it is not necessary that $b = P(B \mid \text{Eagle}) = 0$, as long as the inequality in (7) is satisfied. This could be empirically important. One argument adduced by Schlenker et al. (2014) to treat Campbell's monkey *krak* as a general call is that even in the Tai forest, where it has been described as a leopard-related call, it appears in a small number of cases in eagle-related environments (and the authors point out that this "overextension" of *krak* is greater than the overextension of the eagle call, *hok*, to leopard-related situations; this suggests that mere production errors are not responsible for the overextension of *krak*; rather, the core meaning of *krak* might be general). If so, the Informativity Principle in production is not invariably applied. Still, the exceptions might be rare enough that the Bayesian derivation of the Informativity Principle in comprehension still goes through.

animals, as discussed above, one would have to explain why the comprehension side is needed.

In sum, the most appealing possibility is arguably that the Informativity Principle is primitive in production, and derived from Bayesian reasoning in comprehension.

Evolutionary consequences In recent work, it was argued that simple notions of evolutionary stability in the tradition of Maynard Smith can explain the emergence of the Informativity Principle, viewed (as in all earlier animal linguistics) as primitive (Schlenker et al., forthcoming). It was proposed that there is a clear evolutionary path in which the principle appears in production first, and in comprehension second. The reason was that this evolutionary sequence ensures (irrespective of the detailed pay-offs) that each step increases shared utility and doesn't create misunderstandings. By contrast, some misunderstandings would emerge if the Informativity Principle were applied in comprehension before it arose in production. To see this, suppose a Titi monkey produces a B-call (general alert) in an eagle-related situation, a behavior that is possible without the Informativity Principle in production. A receiver who applied the Informativity Principle in comprehension would wrongly infer that this was not an eagle-related situation, where the A-call would be expected. Miscommunication would ensue.

This reasoning is valid if two evolutionary steps are in fact needed. But our analysis suggests that the second step might be unnecessary—accounting for the emergence of the Informativity Principle in production might be all we need if Bayesian reasoning automatically fills in the second step. This could simplify the analysis of the evolutionary emergence of the Informativity Principle.

In addition, future work might have to revisit the details of the first step. In a nutshell, on the assumption that the receivers perform Bayesian reasoning on the sender's behavior, a mutant that adopts the Informativity Principle in production might produce more shared utility than was envisioned in earlier models, which took the receiver *not* to be Bayesian.

5 Conclusion

In sum, simple Bayesianism could obviate the need for some uses of the Informativity Principle applied in comprehension. However it cannot obviate the need for the Informativity Principle applied in production. Key data that motivated the animal Informativity Principle were based on production, not comprehension. Thus either senders can reason on the receivers' Bayesian behavior, or the Informativity Principle must be taken as primitive in production. To the extent that the first disjunct is implausible (in view of current data on monkeys' theory of mind), the second disjunct must be accepted. This makes plausible a new division of labor between the Informativity Principle and Bayesian reasoning: the principle must be taken as primitive in its production side but it can be taken as derived in its comprehension side. This has consequences for the evolution of the Informativity Principle. Recent studies took the principle to arise from a two-step evolutionary process—plausibly with production first, and comprehension second. Our analysis shows that the second step could be dispensed with.

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